



Online influencer persona, content quality, and the path to purchase: an SEM investigation

Arijit Bhattacharya¹

Received: 30 October 2025 / Accepted: 5 August 2026

© The Author(s), under exclusive licence to Springer Nature B.V. 2026, modified publication 2026

Abstract

As Indian Gen Z consumers increasingly rely on online influencers, an important question arises: what drives their purchase decisions? Influencer-marketing literature largely originates from Western contexts and often assumes that persuasive content is the key. However, content cues may not work the way we expect in a fast-paced, scroll-based digital media environment. In this cross-sectional sample, recommendation credibility was shaped more strongly by influencer persona cues than by post-level content cues. Perceived content quality did not significantly translate into recommendation credibility, and content relevance did not significantly predict perceived content quality. Purchase intention followed a clearer sequential route: trustworthiness and expertise strengthened recommendation credibility, recommendation credibility enhanced parasocial interaction (PSI), and PSI increased purchase intention. Bootstrapped indirect effects further supported this sequence: recommendation credibility influenced purchase intention through PSI, while trustworthiness and expertise operated through recommendation credibility and PSI. The PSI-purchase intention link appeared stronger among female respondents, although this moderation finding is interpreted cautiously. Overall, the findings qualify rather than overturn existing influencer-persuasion models. We use the term ‘person–post decoupling’ cautiously as an interpretive label for the empirical pattern observed in this specific Indian Gen Z, short-form, algorithmically curated media context: respondents appeared to evaluate the credibility of recommendations primarily through relatively stable persona cues rather than through the perceived quality of individual posts. The findings further suggest that credible, authentic, domain-specific influencers matter more than production polish alone. In India’s high-clutter creator economy, informative content, audience relationship-building, and clear sponsorship disclosure remain important.

Keywords Influencer marketing · Parasocial interaction · Elaboration likelihood model · Gen Z · India

✉ Arijit Bhattacharya
arijit.bhattacharya@ibsindia.org

¹ IBS Mumbai, Mumbai, India

1 Introduction

“She used it, so I bought it.” The way Indian Gen Z consumers often decide what to buy is captured in this line. Social media influencers, viewed by this generation of digital natives as “people like me,” often influence purchase decisions, as Gen Z is sceptical of traditional advertising (Rasmussen 2018). Influencers are now perceived as digital peers who shape decisions about food, fashion, and lifestyle (De Veirman et al. 2017), rather than just as low-cost media channels (Lim et al. 2025). A fashion influencer’s lipstick, a fitness influencer’s protein brand, or a technology reviewer’s assessment of a gadget might swiftly convert Gen Z from scrolling to purchasing (Djafarova and Bowes 2021).

With over 400 million social media users and a largely young population, India offers a relevant context for influencer marketing. As brands continue to increase spending on influencer collaborations, the Indian influencer-marketing sector is projected to grow at a CAGR of 25% and reach approximately ₹2200 crore by 2025 (GroupM India et al. 2021). However, the factors that drive purchase intention in this domain—whether the post itself, the influencer, or the influencer-follower bond—remain underexplored (Duffett and Mxunyelwa 2025).

Prior research suggests that source credibility, message value and content quality shape persuasion in influencer marketing (Liu and Wei 2024; Sokolova and Kefi 2020; Lou and Yuan 2019). However, many models developed largely in Western and relatively lower-clutter contexts assume that evaluation of the influencer’s post (for example, argument quality, production value and perceived relevance) will translate into stronger endorsement or recommendation credibility (Casaló et al. 2020; müş and Duyar 2024). In India’s mobile-first and short-form social media environment, Gen Z users may instead rely more heavily on peripheral source cues such as trustworthiness and expertise when attention is scarce and feed content is rapidly consumed.

Accordingly, this study examines two questions in the Indian Gen Z context. First, do content characteristics such as relevance, informativeness and entertainment predict perceived content quality in an algorithmically curated feed environment? Second, does perceived content quality translate into recommendation credibility, or do followers infer recommendation credibility primarily from influencer persona cues such as trustworthiness, expertise and attractiveness? We also test whether the final step from parasocial interaction (PSI) to purchase intention differs by gender.

Using the Elaboration Likelihood Model (ELM) as the core theoretical lens, and drawing on Source Credibility Theory and Parasocial Interaction (PSI) theory as supporting mechanisms, we conducted a cross-sectional survey ($N=415$) and analysed the data using Structural Equation Modelling (SEM). The results show that recommendation credibility was predicted primarily by trustworthiness and expertise, that recommendation credibility strengthened PSI, and that PSI predicted purchase intention. Bootstrap analysis of indirect and total effects further showed that recommendation credibility influenced purchase intention indirectly through PSI, while trustworthiness and expertise influenced purchase intention sequentially through recommendation credibility and PSI. By contrast, content relevance did not significantly predict perceived content quality, and perceived content quality did not significantly predict recommendation credibility. These findings should be regarded cautiously as context-specific data, and not as evidence that content cues are generally insignificant. The results indicate that when developing creative briefs for Indian Gen Z

audiences, marketers should focus on informational value rather than just visual polish and use influencers who show domain competence, consistency and reliability. Given the role of PSI in purchase intention, campaigns may also benefit from relationship-building cues, while treating the gender finding cautiously. Lastly, open and honest sponsorship disclosure is still crucial for both long-term follower trust and regulatory compliance.

2 Literature review: theoretical framework and hypotheses development

A new generation of opinion leaders known as online influencers has transformed commercial communications. Their relatable communication approach, which is founded on intimacy, familiarity, and trust, as well as their specialised fan communities, are what make them valuable (Schouten et al. 2021). These qualities can foster parasocial ties, which form an important basis of influencer persuasiveness. Compared to traditional celebrities, who typically develop a more distant image, they take a different approach (Jin and Phua 2014; Labrecque 2014).

With 467 million social media users and a median age of 28, India offers a relevant environment for studying influencer marketing (Kemp 2023). Users' exposure to crowded, fast-paced influencer material has increased due to the growing dominance of short-form video formats like Instagram Reels inside this vast, young, and emerging digital market. Because of this, Gen Z users' behavioural and cognitive reactions in these platform-specific settings can be different from those seen in previous social media scenarios, requiring more explanation (Meta 2025).

The precise configuration of content and source signals that influences persuasion among Indian Gen Z is still poorly understood, despite meta-analyses agreeing on general drivers like valuable content and transparent influencer disclosure (Pan et al. 2025).

This generation offers a useful setting in which to refine existing persuasion assumptions because of its digital nativity, short attention spans, mobile-first media habits, and strong sensitivity to authenticity. We therefore develop the research model around ELM as the organising logic, using source credibility cues to explain how peripheral persona signals shape recommendation credibility, and PSI theory to explain how credibility is converted into an affective route to purchase intention. In doing so, the study asks whether established influencer-persuasion linkages are qualified under short-form, algorithmically curated conditions rather than assuming that they operate uniformly across contexts.

Recent work on implicit networks of influence further suggests that influencer persuasion should not be viewed as a flat process in which one follower equals one equivalent unit of impact. In algorithmic ecosystems, some actors and recommendation neighbourhoods operate as bridges across communities, while over-specialised recommendation agents can narrow users into restricted preference spaces. Although the present study remains focused on individual-level persuasion, these network-level insights help position influencer personas within broader algorithmic systems that shape the reach, diversity and durability of recommendations (Baccelloni et al. 2025, 2026).

2.1 Theoretical foundations: an ELM-centred persuasion framework

This study uses ELM as the central theoretical lens for explaining influencer persuasion in high-speed social media feeds. Source Credibility Theory and PSI theory are not treated as parallel, disconnected frameworks; rather, they specify the cue inputs and affective mechanism within the broader ELM logic.

ELM explains why consumers may rely on different types of cues depending on motivation, ability and opportunity to elaborate (Petty and Cacioppo 1986). Under central-route processing, consumers carefully evaluate message arguments; under peripheral-route processing, they rely on simpler cues such as source expertise, trustworthiness or attractiveness. In short-form, infinitely scrolling feeds, Indian Gen Z consumers may have limited opportunity for sustained elaboration. Therefore, even when content is relevant or visually polished, persona-based cues may become more diagnostic than post-level execution cues in shaping the credibility of recommendations.

Within this ELM-centred framework, Source Credibility Theory helps identify the salient peripheral cues. Trustworthiness, expertise and attractiveness are treated here as source-based antecedents rather than as reflective dimensions of the mediator. These cues may transfer credibility to the influencer's product-related recommendations, consistent with endorsement-transfer arguments in celebrity and influencer research (Spry et al. 2011; Wang and Scheinbaum 2018; Gong et al. 2024). We expect trustworthiness and expertise to be especially diagnostic for sceptical Gen Z audiences, while attractiveness may be more useful for initial attention than for sustained belief in recommendations.

PSI theory explains the downstream affective mechanism. Once followers perceive an influencer's recommendations as credible, repeated exposure, direct-address communication and perceived familiarity can convert that cognitive evaluation into a felt relational bond (Horton and Wohl 1956; Labrecque 2014). In the present model, PSI therefore mediates the route from recommendation credibility to purchase intention: credible recommendations become persuasive partly because they are received as advice from a familiar and trusted digital companion.

Thus, ELM provides the organising persuasion logic, Source Credibility Theory specifies the persona cues that operate as peripheral inputs to recommendation credibility, and PSI theory explains how that credibility is converted into purchase intention through a relationship-like bond.

2.2 Content quality

Perceived content quality represents the audience's evaluation of a piece of content's overall worth, structural clarity, and production quality (Lee and Watkins 2016). Prior research has shown that content characteristics influence followers' behavioural engagement, such as liking, commenting on, and sharing social media posts (Tafesse and Wood 2021; Schreiner et al. 2021). Against this backdrop, this study re-examines the conventional roles of three key antecedents in the Indian Gen Z context.

2.2.1 Content relevance

Content relevance refers to the extent to which followers perceive an influencer's content as matching their identity, interests, and goals (De Vries et al. 2012). In algorithmically curated short-form feeds, however, such relevance may be embedded in the viewing experience as a basic expectation rather than a distinctive signal of quality. We therefore use the term "hygiene factor" metaphorically (Herzberg et al. 1959) to characterise relevance as a baseline condition: necessary to prevent negative evaluations, but insufficient on its own to produce favourable judgements. Accordingly, this study examines whether relevance continues to predict perceived content quality among Indian Gen Z users in this context.

H1a: *Content relevance positively influences perceived content quality.*

2.2.2 Content informativeness

The degree to which a communication lowers uncertainty and facilitates decision-making by being helpful, thorough, and understandable is referred to as content informativeness (Cheung et al. 2009). From an ELM point of view, informativeness works as a central-route cue since it gives significant details that can facilitate more in-depth message analysis. Informational value in influencer marketing, such as that given by detailed gadget reviews or makeup tutorials, has been linked to increased consumer trust and purchase intention (Lou and Yuan 2019). It may also influence perceptions of influencer expertise (Sokolova and Kefi 2020). Because it provides useful value and influences evaluations of content quality, informative and usable material may continue to stand out in online feeds that are dominated by fleeting entertainment.

H1b: *Content informativeness positively influences perceived content quality.*

2.2.3 Content entertainment value

Entertainment value reflects the hedonic and emotional gratification derived from content, including humour, storytelling, and aesthetic appeal (Ducoffe 1995). Media users are often motivated by the desire to be entertained (Vorderer et al. 2004). In influencer marketing, entertaining posts have been shown to increase enjoyment, engagement, and relational closeness toward the influencer (Lim et al. 2017). However, when entertainment overshadows substantive content, it may also be perceived as superficial or overly commercial. Therefore, this study examines whether entertainment value positively influences perceived content quality in this context.

H1c: *Content entertainment value positively influences perceived content quality.*

2.2.4 Recommendation credibility

In this study, recommendation credibility refers to the audience's overall judgement that an influencer's product- or brand-related recommendations are believable, accurate and authentic. This wording is aligned with the measurement items used in Appendix A. We

therefore reposition the mediator as recommendation credibility rather than influencer credibility. Trustworthiness, expertise and attractiveness are modelled as antecedent source cues that can transfer credibility to the recommendation, rather than as dimensions of the same credibility construct (Spry et al. 2011; Wang and Scheinbaum 2018; Gong et al. 2024).

Followers seldom have direct access to an influencer's true intentions or competence in online settings. Consequently, when judging whether a recommendation should be accepted, they draw on available source cues such as perceived trustworthiness, expertise and attractiveness. These cues help followers infer whether a recommendation reflects authentic experience, competent judgement or merely promotional performance. The model therefore proposes that recommendation credibility is positively predicted by trustworthiness, expertise and attractiveness.

2.2.5 Trustworthiness

Trustworthiness is defined as the degree to which an influencer is seen as honest, sincere, and dependable. As followers evaluate whether influencer recommendations come from real experience or opportunistic persuasion, trustworthiness is a crucial cue in the development of credibility. Authenticity, self-disclosure, and consistency of online persona have been linked to perceived trustworthiness in influencer marketing (Djafarova and Rushworth 2017). Also, transparent disclosure of sponsorship can boost audience trust (Audrezet et al. 2020). Generally, explicit disclosures are viewed as more engaging and reliable than those that are vague (Saternus et al. 2024). This cue may be important to Gen Z consumers, who are known to be sensitive to inauthenticity and persuasive intent.

H2a: *Influencer trustworthiness positively influences recommendation credibility.*

2.2.6 Expertise

The degree to which an influencer is regarded as competent and skilled in a pertinent field is referred to as expertise (Ki and Kim 2019). By indicating if the influencer can provide trustworthy product reviews, it acts as a diagnostic cue. In higher-involvement judgements, thorough explanations and evidence-based comparisons, for example, a technology reviewer describing processor metrics and performance trade-offs, may reinforce perceptions of expertise. At the same time, expertise can act as a heuristic cue that makes decision-making easier when attention is scarce. By making expertise more evident in real time, interactive techniques including live Q&As, demonstrations, and co-creation with followers may further strengthen perceived expertise (He et al. 2021).

H2b: *Influencer expertise positively influences recommendation credibility.*

2.2.7 Attractiveness

Influencer characteristics like charisma, style, and physical appeal that may influence consumers' buying intentions are referred to as attractiveness (Kim 2023). According to the Match-Up Hypothesis (Kamins 1990; Till and Busler 2000), if the influencer's persona is in sync with the product being promoted, persuasion works best. But the ability of attractive-

ness to maintain trust and credibility is increasingly disputed, although it may be effective in capturing initial attention (Lim et al. 2017). According to prior research, attractiveness may even reduce perceived trustworthiness in the absence of meaningful content (Sokolova and Kefi 2020). Social attractiveness, as demonstrated by relatability and likeability, may have a greater impact on Gen Z consumers than physical appeal alone (Chae 2018).

H2c: *Influencer attractiveness positively influences recommendation credibility.*

2.2.8 Content quality and recommendation credibility

The perceived believability of recommendations can be enhanced by higher production value and better message execution which indicate effort and professionalism (Casaló et al. 2020). However, in algorithmically driven and commercialised influencer environments, followers may differentiate a specific post's evaluation from the broader evaluation of the recommendation, relying more on persona-based cues such as expertise and trustworthiness. Against this backdrop, the present study examines whether perceived content quality continues to predict recommendation credibility in the Indian Gen Z context.

H2d: *Content quality positively influences recommendation credibility.*

2.3 The affective pathway

2.3.1 Recommendation credibility fosters parasocial interaction (PSI)

Parasocial interaction (PSI) is more likely to emerge when followers perceive an influencer's recommendations as credible. Credible recommendations reduce psychological distance because they make the influencer appear reliable, knowledgeable and aligned with followers' interests. This perceived bond strengthens persuasive influence by making recommendations feel more like advice from a trusted friend than like commercial communication (Labrecque 2014; Sokolova and Kefi 2020).

H3: *Recommendation credibility positively influences parasocial interaction.*

2.3.2 PSI drives purchase intention

Parasocial interaction (PSI) strengthens the persuasive power of influencer endorsements by making sponsored recommendations feel more like advice from a trusted acquaintance than like commercial communication (Sokolova and Perez 2021). As followers' felt relationship with the influencer deepens, they may become more receptive to acting on endorsements (Sokolova and Kefi 2020), which in turn may increase purchase intention (Aw et al. 2021) and impulse-buying tendency (Xiang et al. 2016).

H4: *Parasocial interaction positively influences purchase intention.*

2.3.3 The moderating role of gender

Prior parasocial-interaction and media-psychology research suggests that audiences may differ in how relational bonds are translated into behavioural intentions (Tukachinsky 2010; Aw and Chuah 2021; Chae 2018). Female followers have often been found to report stronger relational engagement, identification and emotional responsiveness in social-media influencer contexts, whereas male followers may place relatively greater weight on functional or utilitarian cues depending on category involvement. In the present model, we examine whether gender changes the strength of the relationship between parasocial interaction and purchase intention. We do not treat gender as a fixed or universal difference; instead, we examine whether the PSI–purchase intention relationship appears stronger for one group in this specific sample and context.

Gender is examined in this study to test whether parasocial interaction leads to purchase intention equally for male and female followers, or whether this relationship is stronger for one group. The rationale is not that male and female consumers are inherently different in a fixed biological sense, but that gendered socialisation, self-construal, and information-processing tendencies may shape how relational bonds are converted into marketplace action. Social role theory suggests that women are often socialised toward communal, relational, and emotionally expressive orientations, whereas men are more often socialised toward agentic, task-oriented, and instrumental orientations (Eagly 1987). Similarly, research on gendered self-construal argues that women, on average, tend to define the self more relationally and interdependently, whereas men are more likely to emphasise autonomy and separateness (Cross and Madson 1997). These tendencies may influence how followers interpret the felt intimacy, familiarity, and friendship embedded in parasocial relationships with influencers.

From a consumer-information-processing perspective, gender may also influence the relative weight given to relational versus functional cues. Prior consumer research suggests that women are often more likely to engage in comprehensive, context-sensitive, and affectively embedded processing, while men may rely more selectively on highly diagnostic or task-relevant cues, depending on product category and involvement level (Meyers-Levy and Loken 2015). In influencer-marketing settings, PSI is fundamentally relational: it reflects perceived friendship, emotional closeness, familiarity, and the feeling that the influencer is personally known to the follower (Tukachinsky 2010; Labrecque 2014). Therefore, when PSI is strong, female followers may be more likely to translate this relational attachment into behavioural intention, because the recommendation is processed less as an impersonal advertisement and more as advice from a trusted, familiar social referent.

This argument is also consistent with recent influencer-marketing research. According to studies (Sokolova and Kefi 2020; Aw and Chuah 2021), parasocial interactions with social media influencers can boost product interest and purchase intention because followers perceive the influencer as a reliable and familiar quasi-social partner. According to research on how female followers react to social media influencers, influencer content can increase women's identification, emotional comparison, and relational involvement in categories related to looks, lifestyle, and identity (Chae 2018). Because relational proximity may function as a more persuasive conversion mechanism, the PSI–purchase intention association may be higher among female followers. However, rather than framing gender moderation as a fundamental or universal gender difference, this study frames it as probabilistic, context-

specific, and category-dependent. Male followers may also respond strongly to PSI when the influencer is highly trusted, when the product category is personally involving, or when the influencer provides strong functional value.

Based on this reasoning, gender is expected to moderate the relationship between parasocial interaction and purchase intention, such that the positive effect of PSI on purchase intention is likely to be stronger among female followers than among male followers.

H5: *Gender moderates the relationship between parasocial interaction and purchase intention, such that the positive relationship is stronger among female followers than among male followers.*

2.4 Research model and hypothesised development summary

The conceptual model examines whether post-level content cues and influencer persona cues contribute differently to the persuasion process. Content relevance, informativeness, and entertainment are modelled as antecedents of perceived content quality. Trustworthiness, expertise, attractiveness, and perceived content quality are modelled as antecedents of recommendation credibility. Recommendation credibility is then expected to strengthen parasocial interaction (PSI), which in turn predicts purchase intention. Gender is modelled as a moderator of the PSI–purchase intention relationship. In this way, the model examines whether followers evaluate recommendation credibility mainly through influencer persona cues rather than through the perceived quality of individual posts. The conceptual model is presented in Fig. 1.

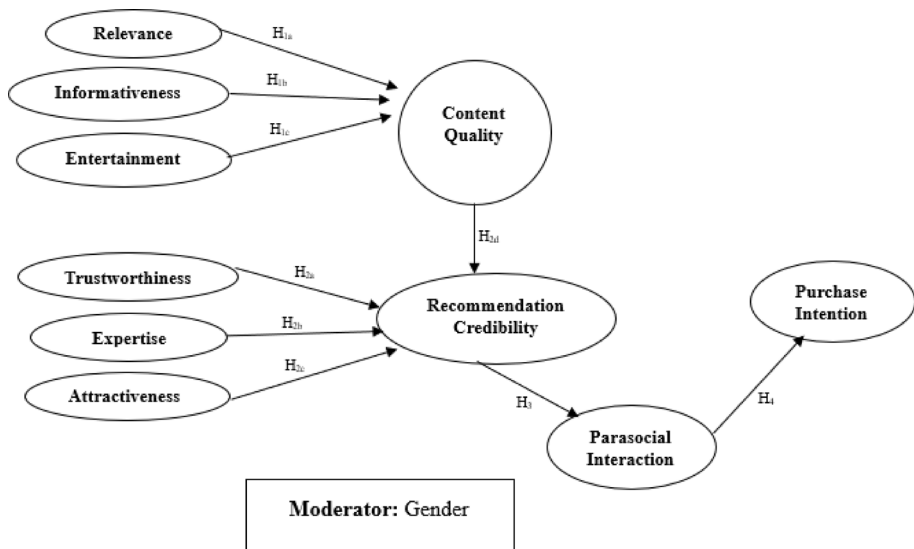


Fig. 1 Conceptual (hypothesised) model

2.5 Research methodology

2.5.1 Research design and data collection

To empirically test the proposed conceptual model, this study adopted a quantitative cross-sectional online survey design. This approach was appropriate for capturing the perceptions and behavioural intentions of the target population and for applying Structural Equation Modelling (SEM) to analyse the complex relationships among latent constructs (Bagozzi and Yi 1988).

2.5.2 Sampling and procedure

The target population comprised Indian Gen Z social media users aged 18–28 years who currently follow at least one social media influencer. Because an accessible probability sampling frame for this specific digital cohort is difficult to obtain, a non-probability approach was adopted, combining convenience sampling with purposive eligibility screening (Etikan et al. 2016). After the eligibility question, respondents were instructed to answer the substantive items by thinking of one focal influencer whom they follow and whose product or brand recommendations they had encountered. This focal-influencer frame was used so that responses to items such as ‘this influencer’ and ‘this influencer’s recommendations’ referred to a specific and salient source rather than to influencers in general.

To obtain a varied, though non-random, sample of Gen Z respondents across India, the survey was distributed through professional networks, social media groups and student forums. Google Forms was used to administer the survey online (Ilieva et al. 2002). Data were gathered over six weeks. Participation was voluntary, anonymous and uncompensated. A total of 72 ineligible responses were eliminated through screening, leaving a final usable sample of 415 respondents.

2.5.3 Sample profile

The demographic characteristics of the sample are shown in Table 1. Strong congruence with the study’s focus on Indian Gen Z is indicated by the profile. 74.7% of respondents were between the ages of 18 and 22, with the remaining respondents being between the ages of 23 and 28. With 48.4% of respondents being men and 51.6% being women, the gender distribution was almost equal. 71.6% of participants were students, and 66% had a bachelor’s degree or were working toward one. The majority of households (42.8%) reported monthly income between ₹50,000 and ₹100,000.

The high percentage of students in this sample may limit the findings’ applicability to Gen Z segments that are not students or employed.

2.6 Measures and diagnostic checks

2.6.1 Survey instrument

Thirty items measuring ten latent components make up the survey instrument. The scale’s items were modified from established sources. Each dimension was measured using a

Table 1 Demographic profile of respondents

Sample profile	Sample %
<i>Gender (N=415)</i>	
Male	48.4
Female	51.6
<i>Age (in years)</i>	
18–22	74.7
23–28	25.3
<i>Education level</i>	
Undergraduate	23
Bachelor's degree	66
Post-graduate	11
<i>Occupation</i>	
Student	71.6
Employed	28.4
<i>Monthly household income</i>	
< ₹50,000	36.4
₹50,000- ₹100,000	42.8
> ₹100,000	20.8

7-point Likert scale, where 1 represents strongly disagree and 7 represents strongly agree. Standardised factor loadings at the item level and construct-level validity and reliability statistics (CR and AVE) are displayed in Table 2. The measurement instrument is shown in Appendix A.

2.7 Procedural and diagnostic checks

In accordance with Podsakoff et al. (2003), a number of procedural safeguards were employed to improve data integrity and lessen potential common method bias (CMB). In order to reduce evaluation apprehension and establish psychological separation across constructs, respondent anonymity was guaranteed, item wording was kept straightforward, and introductory instructions were employed. As a simple post hoc diagnostic screen, we also performed Harman's single-factor test. Below the traditional 50% criterion, the first unrotated factor explained 28.4% of the total variation. Harman's test, however, has limitations and shouldn't be used as a robustness test or as conclusive proof that CMB doesn't exist.

Second, non-response bias was evaluated by comparing early and late respondents (Armstrong and Overton 1977). Independent-samples t-tests on construct scores and key demographic characteristics (age and gender) showed no statistically significant differences ($p > 0.05$), suggesting that non-response bias is unlikely to be a serious concern. A pilot study with 30 members of the target demographic was also conducted to check the questionnaire's clarity, flow and comprehensibility.

2.8 Data analysis

Following the two-step approach recommended by Anderson and Gerbing (1988), we used Structural Equation Modelling (SEM) in AMOS (v30) to analyse the data. First, Confirmatory Factor Analysis (CFA) was conducted to estimate the measurement model and assess reliability and validity. Second, the structural model was estimated to test the hypothesised

Table 2 Measurement items and measurement model statistics

Construct (source)	Item	Factor loading	Convergent validity (AVE>0.5)	Composite reliability	Discriminant validity ($\sqrt{\text{AVE}}$ > interconstruct correlations)
Relevance	RE1	0.78	0.64	0.86	Yes
	RE2	0.80			
	RE3	0.82			
Informativeness	IN1	0.82	0.59	0.83	Yes
	IN2	0.76			
	IN3	0.74			
Entertainment	EN1	0.68	0.51	0.77	Yes
	EN2	0.71			
	EN3	0.73			
Trustworthiness	TW1	0.85	0.68	0.88	Yes
	TW2	0.81			
	TW3	0.83			
Expertise	EX1	0.79	0.63	0.85	Yes
	EX2	0.81			
	EX3	0.77			
Attractiveness	AT1	0.69	0.51	0.77	Yes
	AT2	0.73			
	AT3	0.71			
Content quality	CQ1	0.84	0.65	0.86	Yes
	CQ2	0.79			
	CQ3	0.80			
Recommendation credibility	RC1	0.81	0.63	0.84	Yes
	RC2	0.78			
	RC3	0.80			
Parasocial interaction	PSI1	0.75	0.58	0.82	Yes
	PSI2	0.77			
	PSI3	0.76			
Purchase intention	PI1	0.82	0.65	0.86	Yes
	PI2	0.80			
	PI3	0.81			

paths, and standardised regression weights (β), critical ratios (C.R.), and p-values were reported. To examine gender moderation (H5), we conducted a multi-group analysis (male vs. female) using χ^2 -difference tests between unconstrained and constrained models. Path-specific constraints were then applied to identify the relationship moderated by gender. Finally, direct, indirect, and total effects were examined using the bootstrapping procedure in AMOS with 5,000 resamples and 95% confidence intervals.

2.8.1 Reliability and validity of the instrument

Confirmatory Factor Analysis (CFA) was used to assess the measurement model and evaluate the reliability, convergent validity, and discriminant validity of the latent constructs. CFA was appropriate because the measurement items were adapted from established scales and the study tested a theoretically specified construct structure. The assessment focused

on standardised factor loadings, Composite Reliability (CR), Average Variance Extracted (AVE), and discriminant validity.

2.8.2 Measurement model assessment

CFA was conducted to assess the measurement model before examining the structural relationships. The model showed an acceptable fit ($\chi^2/df=1.85$, CFI=0.918, TLI=0.905, RMSEA=0.065), suggesting a reasonable level of consistency between the proposed factor structure and the observed covariance matrix. Following commonly used SEM guidelines, χ^2/df below 3, CFI and TLI close to or above 0.90, and RMSEA below 0.08 indicate acceptable fit, although the values should be interpreted collectively rather than mechanically (Hooper et al. 2008).

As shown in Table 2, convergent validity was supported by statistically significant standardised loadings ($p<0.001$) that exceeded the recommended thresholds. For every construct, Composite Reliability (CR) was greater than 0.70 and Average Variance Extracted (AVE) was greater than 0.50. The Fornell–Larcker criterion (Fornell and Larcker 1981) was used to evaluate discriminant validity, confirming that the constructs were empirically distinct.

2.8.3 Structural model and hypothesis testing

To investigate the proposed relationships, we estimated the structural model after verifying the measurement model (Fig. 2). The model demonstrated acceptable, though not perfect fit ($\chi^2/df=1.95$, CFI=0.910, TLI=0.898, RMSEA=0.069). The CFI and RMSEA were within acceptable ranges, while the TLI was marginally below the 0.90 rule-of-thumb threshold; therefore, the model fit is treated as adequate for hypothesis testing but interpreted with appropriate caution. Table 3 displays the p-values, critical ratios (C.R.) and standardised path coefficients (β) for each hypothesis.

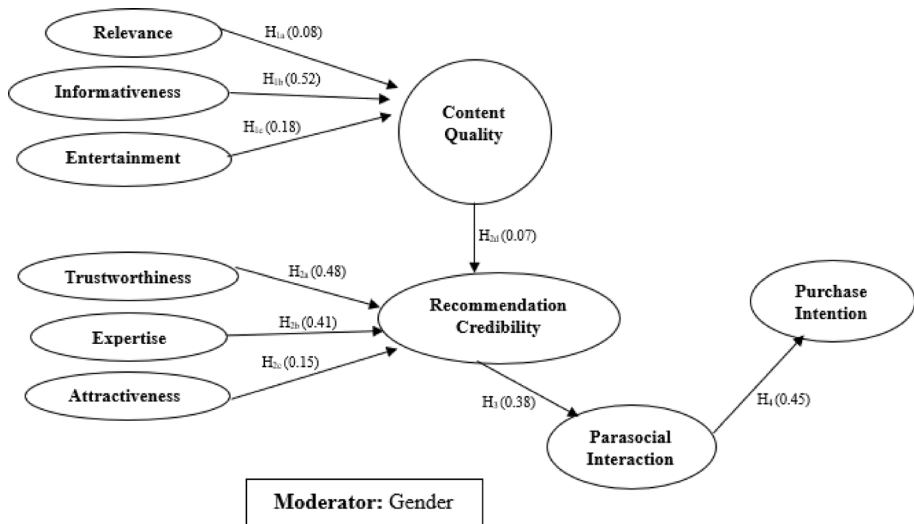


Fig. 2 Estimated structural model with standardised path coefficients (β)

Content Quality Antecedents (H1): There was no evidence to support the path from content relevance to perceived content quality (H1a) ($\beta=0.08$, $p=0.230$). One explanation could be that relevance serves as a baseline condition rather than a powerful differentiator of perceived quality in algorithmically curated feeds. On the other hand, content entertainment (H1c) demonstrated a smaller but still significant positive effect ($\beta=0.18$, $p=0.036$), and content informativeness (H1b) strongly predicted perceived content quality ($\beta=0.52$, $p<0.001$).

Recommendation Credibility Antecedents (H2): The strongest predictors of recommendation credibility were trustworthiness (H2a) and expertise (H2b) ($\beta=0.48$ and $\beta=0.41$, respectively; both $p<0.001$). The effect of attractiveness (H2c) was weaker but statistically significant ($\beta=0.15$, $p=0.048$). There was no evidence to support the hypothesised positive relationship between perceived content quality and recommendation credibility (H2d) ($\beta=0.07$, $p=0.250$). Rather than treating this as proof that content quality never matters, we interpret it as a context-specific absence of support for the expected positive linkage in this sample.

Recommendation Credibility, PSI, and Purchase Intention (H3-H4): Recommendation credibility positively predicted parasocial interaction (H3) ($\beta=0.38$, $p<0.001$). Parasocial interaction, in turn, positively predicted purchase intention (H4) ($\beta=0.45$, $p<0.001$), supporting the proposed affective route from credible recommendations to purchase intention through PSI. Because the model specifies a sequential pathway, formal indirect and total effects are reported in the following subsection using AMOS bootstrapping.

2.9 Direct, indirect, and total effects

Given the sequential structure of the model, direct, indirect, and total effects were examined using the bootstrapping procedure in AMOS. Standardised estimates are reported, and 95% bootstrap confidence intervals were generated using 5,000 resamples. An indirect effect was treated as statistically significant when the confidence interval did not include zero. In the specified model, only parasocial interaction (PSI) had a direct path to purchase intention; for all antecedent variables, the total effect on purchase intention therefore represents their indirect effect through the modelled sequential pathway.

As shown in Table 4, PSI had the strongest effect on purchase intention, $\beta=0.450$, 95% CI [0.310, 0.580]. Recommendation credibility influenced purchase intention indirectly through PSI, $\beta=0.171$, 95% CI [0.108, 0.247]. Among the source-related antecedents,

Table 3 Hypothesis testing results

#	Hypothesis	Std. β	C.R.	p -value	Interpretation
1	H1a: Content relevance $\rightarrow$ Content quality	0.08	1.20	0.230	Not supported
2	H1b: Content informativeness $\rightarrow$ Content quality	0.52	4.80	<0.001	Supported
3	H1c: Content entertainment value $\rightarrow$ Content quality	0.18	2.10	0.036	Supported
4	H2a: Trustworthiness $\rightarrow$ Recommendation credibility	0.48	5.60	<0.001	Supported
5	H2b: Expertise $\rightarrow$ Recommendation credibility	0.41	5.10	<0.001	Supported
6	H2c: Attractiveness $\rightarrow$ Recommendation credibility	0.15	1.98	0.048	Supported
7	H2d: Content quality $\rightarrow$ Recommendation credibility	0.07	1.15	0.250	Not supported
8	H3: Recommendation credibility $\rightarrow$ Parasocial interaction	0.38	3.50	<0.001	Supported
9	H4: Parasocial interaction $\rightarrow$ Purchase intention	0.45	4.20	<0.001	Supported

C.R. = Critical ratio; standardised coefficients are reported

trustworthiness, $\beta=0.082$, 95% CI [0.047, 0.126], and expertise, $\beta=0.070$, 95% CI [0.038, 0.111], showed significant sequential indirect effects on purchase intention. Attractiveness showed a smaller but significant indirect effect, $\beta=0.026$, 95% CI [0.001, 0.060].

By contrast, the content-based pathways were not supported. The indirect effect of content quality on purchase intention was small and non-significant, $\beta=0.012$, 95% CI [-0.006, 0.037]. The longer indirect effects from content informativeness, entertainment, and relevance were also negligible and non-significant. Overall, the integrated effects suggest that purchase intention in this sample is driven primarily by PSI and by source-based credibility cues, especially trustworthiness and expertise, rather than by post-level content-quality cues.

2.9.1 Moderation effect

2.9.1.1 Moderation analysis: the role of gender To examine whether gender moderates the structural relationships in the model, we conducted a multi-group analysis (MGA) comparing male and female respondents. The overall test of model invariance across groups was marginal ($p=0.058$), indicating only limited evidence of gender-based differences at the model level. Therefore, the gender moderation result should be read cautiously. Path-spe-

Table 4 Direct, indirect, and total effects on purchase intention

Predictor	Main route to purchase intention	Direct effect	Indirect effect	Total effect	95% bootstrap CI	Interpretation
Parasocial interaction	PSI → Purchase intention	0.450	–	0.450	[0.310, 0.580]	Strong direct effect
Recommendation credibility	Recommendation credibility → PSI → Purchase intention	–	0.171	0.171	[0.108, 0.247]	Significant indirect effect
Trustworthiness	Trustworthiness → Recommendation credibility → PSI → Purchase intention	–	0.082	0.082	[0.047, 0.126]	Significant sequential indirect effect
Expertise	Expertise → Recommendation credibility → PSI → Purchase intention	–	0.070	0.070	[0.038, 0.111]	Significant sequential indirect effect
Attractiveness	Attractiveness → Recommendation credibility → PSI → Purchase intention	–	0.026	0.026	[0.001, 0.060]	Small but significant indirect effect
Content quality	Content quality → Recommendation credibility → PSI → Purchase intention	–	0.012	0.012	[-0.006, 0.037]	Not significant
Content informativeness	Informativeness → Content quality → Recommendation credibility → PSI → Purchase intention	–	0.006	0.006	[-0.003, 0.022]	Not significant
Content entertainment	Entertainment → Content quality → Recommendation credibility → PSI → Purchase intention	–	0.002	0.002	[-0.002, 0.011]	Not significant
Content relevance	Relevance → Content quality → Recommendation credibility → PSI → Purchase intention	–	0.001	0.001	[-0.004, 0.008]	Not significant

Standardised estimates are reported. A dash indicates that the effect was not estimated in the specified structural model

Table 5 Multi-group (gender) moderation analysis (χ^2 -difference tests)

Model comparison	χ^2	df	$\Delta\chi^2$	Δ df	p-value	Interpretation
Unconstrained model	913.792	792	—	—	—	Baseline model
Fully constrained model	955.631	821	41.839	29	0.058	Marginal evidence of group difference

cific comparisons suggested that the $\text{PSI} \rightarrow \text{purchase intention}$ relationship may be stronger among female respondents, although this pattern should be interpreted cautiously because the overall multi-group comparison was only marginal (Table 5).

Overall, the results provide cautious support for H5, indicating that the PSI –purchase intention relationship may differ by gender, although this pattern should be replicated in other samples before drawing firm conclusions.

3 Discussion and conclusion

3.1 Theoretical implications

This study contributes to influencer-marketing theory in three ways. First, it refines ELM-based influencer-persuasion models by showing that, in this Indian Gen Z sample, persona cues, especially trustworthiness and expertise, were more diagnostic for recommendation credibility than perceived post-level content quality. Second, the bootstrapped indirect-effect results provide evidence consistent with the affective mechanism through which persona cues influence purchase intention: trustworthiness and expertise strengthen recommendation credibility, recommendation credibility enhances PSI , and PSI then increases purchase intention. Third, the non-significant content-based indirect pathways suggest that content-focused explanations of influencer persuasion may not fully explain purchase intention in short-form, algorithmically curated feeds.

The non-significant relevance $\rightarrow$ content quality path (H1a) suggests that relevance may function as a baseline expectation in algorithmically curated feeds. Users often encounter content that is personalised enough to appear relevant but still repetitive, low in value or weakly informative. The finding therefore qualifies rather than rejects existing content-value models: relevance may remain necessary for visibility and attention, but it may not be sufficient to create perceived quality once algorithmic personalisation has already normalised relevance.

This interpretation also points to a possible future integration between individual-level influencer-persuasion models and algorithmic-network perspectives. Influencer impact is not simply a matter of follower count or one-to-one persuasion; it is shaped by whether creators and recommendation systems bridge communities, reinforce narrow clusters, or expose users to more diverse options. Future research can therefore combine individual-level SEM models with network analysis to examine whether bridging influencers, weak-tie recommendation neighbourhoods, or generalised versus specialised recommendation agents alter the reach and credibility of influencer recommendations (Baccelloni et al. 2025, 2026).

The non-significant content quality $\rightarrow$ recommendation credibility path (H2d) indicates that, in this sample and context, followers did not systematically translate post-level execution quality into higher recommendation credibility. One plausible interpretation is that

credibility judgements rely more on relatively stable persona cues such as trustworthiness and expertise, than on the perceived quality of any single piece of content. This pattern is consistent with, though does not prove, the idea that audiences may evaluate the influencer and the post using partially separate heuristics.

The gender moderation finding also refines, but does not settle, PSI theory. The results suggest that the $\text{PSI} \rightarrow \text{purchase intention}$ relationship may be stronger among female respondents in this sample. However, because the overall MGA evidence was only marginal, this pattern should be viewed as exploratory and replicated across product categories, platforms, and influencer types before firm conclusions are drawn.

Overall, the findings qualify existing influencer-marketing models by showing when content cues may lose some diagnostic value and when persona cues may become more central. They do not imply that content is irrelevant; rather, they suggest that in short-form, high-clutter environments, content quality may influence engagement and perceived usefulness without necessarily transferring into recommendation credibility.

In conclusion, this study shows that, for the sampled Indian Gen Z respondents, influencer persuasion is driven primarily by persona-based cues that strengthen recommendation credibility, which then fosters parasocial interaction and purchase intention. At the same time, the data did not support two commonly assumed links: $\text{relevance} \rightarrow \text{perceived content quality}$ and $\text{perceived content quality} \rightarrow \text{recommendation credibility}$. These findings invite future research to examine when, for whom and under what platform conditions message-level cues regain or lose diagnostic value.

3.2 Managerial implications

The findings suggest several India-specific implications for brands targeting Gen Z in a mobile-first, short-video and high-clutter creator economy. In India's multilingual and culturally diverse market, brands should also consider whether the influencer's language, cultural references, and communication style feel familiar to the target audience. First, influencer selection should prioritise trustworthiness and domain expertise because these source cues showed the strongest statistically supported sequential indirect effects on purchase intention through recommendation credibility and PSI.

Second, because content-quality routes did not show significant downstream indirect effects on purchase intention, brands should not treat production polish as a substitute for credible persona cues. Content should still be informative and useful, but its role appears stronger in shaping perceived content quality than in driving purchase intention through the credibility-PSI pathway.

Third, content briefs should emphasise informational value: concrete use cases, product comparisons, transparent pros and cons, price-value reasoning and decision support. Entertainment can help attract attention, but it should support rather than displace clarity and usefulness.

Fourth, transparent sponsorship disclosure should be treated as a trust-building practice rather than merely as a compliance requirement. Clear labels such as 'paid partnership' can protect long-term credibility, especially among Indian Gen Z users who are sensitive to inauthentic or hidden persuasion.

Finally, segmentation should be used cautiously. The exploratory gender finding suggests that relational and community-building cues may be particularly useful for some female

audience segments, but campaigns should avoid stereotyping and should test audience responses by category, platform and creator type.

3.3 Limitations and future research directions

This study has several limitations. First, the design is cross-sectional and relies on self-reported perceptions and intentions; therefore, causal inferences cannot be drawn. Second, the sampling approach was non-probability based (convenience recruitment with purposive eligibility screening), and the sample over-represents students. As a result, the findings should not be generalised to all Indian Gen Z social media users without caution.

Third, content quality and relevance were measured as perceptions rather than through objective coding of posts (for example, production attributes, argument strength and disclosure quality). Future research should triangulate self-reported data with expert content analysis and behavioural outcomes such as click-throughs, watch time, saves, shares and actual purchase behaviour.

Fourth, although this study reports bootstrapped indirect and total effects, the cross-sectional design prevents strong causal claims about the sequential pathway. The indirect effects should therefore be interpreted as evidence of statistically supported associations among the modelled constructs, not as definitive proof of causal mediation. Future research should use longitudinal or experimental designs to test whether recommendation credibility and PSI causally transmit the effects of source cues to purchase intention.

Finally, future research should examine whether the person–post decoupling pattern persists across product categories (high versus low involvement), influencer tiers, languages, regions and platforms such as Instagram, YouTube and TikTok. Longitudinal and experimental designs could also test whether recommendation credibility and PSI evolve differently after repeated exposure, sponsorship disclosure, or AI-assisted content creation.

Appendix A: Measurement instrument

Items were adapted from cited sources to the influencer-content context. Responses were recorded on a 7-point Likert scale (1 = Strongly disagree; 7 = Strongly agree). The credibility construct is labeled recommendation credibility because the CR items assess the believability, accuracy and authenticity of the influencer's recommendations.

Construct	Source	Item	Details
Content relevance	Laczniak and Muehling (1993)	RE1	The influencer's posts are relevant to my interests
		RE2	The influencer's content matches my needs and preferences
		RE3	The influencer's posts fit my lifestyle and values
Content informativeness	Lou and Yuan (2019)	IN1	The influencer's posts provide useful information about products/brands
		IN2	The influencer's posts are detailed and informative
		IN3	The influencer's content helps me understand products/brands better
Content entertainment value	Lou and Yuan (2019)	EN1	I find the influencer's content entertaining
		EN2	The influencer's posts are enjoyable to watch
		EN3	The influencer's content is fun

Construct	Source	Item	Details
Trustworthiness	Ohanian (1990)	TW1	This influencer is honest
		TW2	I can rely on what this influencer says about products
		TW3	This influencer is sincere
Expertise	Ohanian (1990)	EX1	This influencer is an expert in their field
		EX2	This influencer is experienced in this domain/category
		EX3	This influencer is knowledgeable about the products they discuss
Attractiveness	Ohanian (1990)	AT1	This influencer is attractive
		AT2	This influencer is stylish
		AT3	This influencer has an appealing appearance
Perceived content quality	Wixom and Todd (2005)	CQ1	The influencer's content is of high quality
		CQ2	The influencer's posts are well-organized and easy to follow
		CQ3	The influencer's content provides complete information
Recommendation credibility	Appel- man and Sundar (2016)	RC1	This influencer's recommendations are believable
		RC2	This influencer's recommendations are accurate
		RC3	This influencer's recommendations are authentic
Parasocial interaction	Rubin et al. (1985)	PSI1	I feel like I know this influencer well
		PSI2	I feel a sense of friendship with this influencer
		PSI3	Interacting with this influencer feels like interacting with some- one I know
Purchase intention	Lee and Watkins (2016)	PI1	I am likely to purchase products recommended by this influencer
		PI2	I would consider buying products that this influencer recommends
		PI3	I intend to try products promoted by this influencer

Author contributions Arijit Bhattacharya wrote the main manuscript text.

Funding No funding received.

Data availability Datasets were generated or analysed during the current study.

Declarations

Conflict of interest The authors declare no conflict of interest.

References

- Anderson, J.C., Gerbing, D.W.: Structural equation modeling in practice: a review and recommended two-step approach. *Psychol. Bull.* **103**(3), 411–423 (1988). <https://doi.org/10.1037/0033-2909.103.3.411>
- Appelman, A., Sundar, S.S.: Measuring message credibility: construction and validation of an exclusive scale. *Journalism Mass. Communication Q.* **93**(1), 59–79 (2016). <https://doi.org/10.1177/1077699015606057>
- Armstrong, J.S., Overton, T.S.: Estimating nonresponse bias in mail surveys. *J. Mark. Res.* **14**(3), 396–402 (1977). <https://doi.org/10.2307/3150783>
- Audrezet, A., de Kerviler, G., Moulard, J.G.: Authenticity under threat: when social media influencers need to go beyond self-presentation. *J. Bus. Res.* **117**, 557–569 (2020). <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jbusres.2018.07.008>
- Aw, E.C.X., Chuah, S.H.W.: Stop the unattainable ideal for an ordinary me! Fostering parasocial relationships with social media influencers: the role of self-discrepancy. *J. Bus. Res.* **132**, 146–157 (2021). <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jbusres.2021.04.025>
- Baccelloni, A., Mazzù, M.F., Ricotta, F., Mattiacci, A.: Uncovering the role of weak ties in implicit networks of influence: a network analysis on recommendation algorithms' neighborhood. *Eur. J. Mark.* **59**(12), 2725–2762 (2025). <https://doi.org/10.1108/EJM-02-2024-0136>

- Baccelloni, A., De Angelis, M., Ricotta, F., Mazzù, M.F.: Too narrow to help? Unveiling how recommendation agents' specialization impacts user choices. *J. Interact. Mark.* (2026). <https://doi.org/10.1177/10949968251358181>
- Bagozzi, R.P., Yi, Y.: On the evaluation of structural equation models. *J. Acad. Mark. Sci.* **16**(1), 74–94 (1988). <https://doi.org/10.1007/BF02723327>
- Casaló, L.V., Flavián, C., Ibáñez-Sánchez, S.: Influencers on Instagram: antecedents and consequences of opinion leadership. *J. Bus. Res.* **117**, 510–519 (2020). <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jbusres.2018.07.005>
- Chae, J.: Explaining females' envy toward social media influencers. *Media Psychol.* **21**(2), 246–262 (2018). <https://doi.org/10.1080/15213269.2017.1328312>
- Cheung, C.M.K., Lee, M.K.O., Rabjohn, N.: The impact of electronic word-of-mouth: the adoption of online opinions in online customer communities. *Internet Res.* **19**(1), 7–26 (2009). <https://doi.org/10.1108/10662240910927881>
- Cross, S.E., Madson, L.: Models of the self: self-construals and gender. *Psychol. Bull.* **122**(1), 5–37 (1997). <https://doi.org/10.1037/0033-2909.122.1.5>
- De Veirman, M., Cauberghe, V., Hudders, L.: Marketing through Instagram influencers: the impact of number of followers and product divergence on brand attitude. *Int. J. Advertising.* **36**(5), 798–828 (2017). <https://doi.org/10.1080/02650487.2017.1348035>
- De Vries, L., Gensler, S., Leeftang, P.S.H.: Popularity of brand posts on brand fan pages: an investigation of the effects of social media marketing. *J. Interact. Mark.* **26**(2), 83–91 (2012). <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.intmar.2012.01.003>
- Djafarova, E., Bowes, T.: Instagram made me buy it: generation Z impulse purchases in fashion industry. *J. Retail. Consum. Serv.* **59**, 102345 (2021). <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jretconser.2020.102345>
- Djafarova, E., Rushworth, C.: Exploring the credibility of online celebrities' Instagram profiles in influencing the purchase decisions of young female users. *Comput. Hum. Behav.* **68**, 1–7 (2017). <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.chb.2016.11.009>
- Ducoffe, R.H.: How consumers assess the value of advertising. *J. Curr. Issues Res. Advertising.* **17**(1), 1–18 (1995). <https://doi.org/10.1080/10641734.1995.10505033>
- Duffett, R., Mxunyelwa, A.: Instagram mega-influencers' effect on generation Z's intention to purchase: a technology acceptance model and source credibility model perspective. *J. Theoretical Appl. Electron. Commer. Res.* **20**(2), Article94 (2025)
- Eagly, A.H.: Sex differences in social behavior: a social-role interpretation. Lawrence Erlbaum Associates (1987)
- Etikan, I., Musa, S.A., Alkassim, R.S.: Comparison of convenience sampling and purposive sampling. *Am. J. Theoretical Appl. Stat.* **5**(1), 1–4 (2016). <https://doi.org/10.11648/j.ajtas.20160501.11>
- GroupM India, INCA, exchange4media: India influencer marketing report 2021: the new era of intelligent influence. WPP Media (2021). <https://www.datocms-assets.com/153350/1748316047-inca-e4m-india-i-nfluencer-marketing-report-the-new-era-of-intelligent-influence-final.pdf>
- Fornell, C., Larcker, D.F.: Evaluating structural equation models with unobservable variables and measurement error. *J. Mark. Res.* **18**(1), 39–50 (1981). <https://doi.org/10.2307/3151312>
- Gong, W., Li, X.: Engaging fans on microblog: the synthetic influence of parasocial interaction and source characteristics on celebrity endorsement. *Psychol. Mark.* **34**(7), 720–732 (2017). <https://doi.org/10.1002/mar.21018>
- Gümüş, N., Duyar, Ş.: Examination of the impact of trust in influencers and perceived content quality on brand awareness, consumer interaction, and purchase intent. *Interdiscip. Descr. Complex. Syst.* **22**(5), 596–611 (2024)
- He, Y., Tian, X., Yang, Y., Ma, C.: Leveraging live streaming to create credibility and trust in social commerce. *J. Retailing Consumer Serv.* **59**, 102389 (2021). <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jretconser.2020.102389>
- Herzberg, F., Mausner, B., Snyderman, B.B.: The motivation to work. Wiley (1959)
- Hooper, D., Coughlan, J., Mullen, M.: Structural equation modelling: guidelines for determining model fit. *Electron. J. Bus. Res. Methods.* **6**(1), 53–60 (2008)
- Horton, D., Wohl, R.R.: Mass communication and parasocial interaction: observations on intimacy at a distance. *Psychiatry.* **19**(3), 215–229 (1956). <https://doi.org/10.1080/00332747.1956.11023049>
- Ilieva, J., Baron, S., Healey, N.M.: Online surveys in marketing research: pros and cons. *Int. J. Market Res.* **44**(3), 361–376 (2002). <https://doi.org/10.1177/147078530204400303>
- Jin, S.A.A., Phua, J.: Following celebrities' tweets about brands: the impact of Twitter-based electronic word-of-mouth on consumers' source credibility perception, buying intention, and social identification with celebrities. *J. Advertising.* **43**(2), 181–195 (2014). <https://doi.org/10.1080/00913367.2013.827606>
- Kamins, M.A.: An investigation into the match-up hypothesis in celebrity advertising: when beauty may be only skin deep. *J. Advertising.* **19**(1), 4–13 (1990). <https://doi.org/10.1080/00913367.1990.10673175>
- Kemp, S.: Digital 2023: India. DataReportal. (2023). <https://datareportal.com/reports/digital-2023-india>

- Ki, C.-W.C., Kim, Y.-K.: The mechanism by which social media influencers persuade consumers: the role of consumers' desire to mimic. *Psychol. Mark.* **36**(10), 905–922 (2019). <https://doi.org/10.1002/mar.21244>
- Kim, H.: Virtual influencers' attractiveness effect on purchase intention: the mediating role of mimetic desire. *Comput. Hum. Behav.* **143**, 107703 (2023). <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.chb.2023.107703>
- Labrecque, L.I.: Fostering consumer–brand relationships in social media environments: the role of parasocial interaction. *J. Interact. Mark.* **28**(2), 134–148 (2014). <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.intmar.2013.12.003>
- Laczniak, R.N., Muehling, D.D.: Toward a better understanding of the role of advertising message involvement in ad processing. *Psychol. Mark.* **10**(4), 301–319 (1993). <https://doi.org/10.1002/mar.4220100402>
- Lee, J.E., Watkins, B.: YouTube vloggers' influence on consumer luxury brand perceptions and intentions. *J. Bus. Res.* **69**(12), 5753–5760 (2016). <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jbusres.2016.04.171>
- Lim, X.J., Radzol, A.M., Cheah, J.-H., Wong, M.W.: The impact of social media influencers on purchase intention and the mediation effect of customer attitude. *Asian J. Bus. Res.* **7**(2), 19–36 (2017)
- Lim, W.M., Koay, K.Y., Cheah, C.W.: Commercialization of influencer content on social media: The roles of parasocial relationships and sponsorship disclosures. *J. Strategic Mark.* **33**(5), 658–684 (2025)
- Liu, X., Wei, X.: The persuasive power of social media influencers: an ELM–PSI perspective. *Humanit. Social Sci. Commun.* **11**, 15. (2024)
- Lou, C., Yuan, S.: Influencer marketing: how message value and credibility affect consumer trust of branded content on social media. *J. Interact. Advertising.* **19**(1), 58–73 (2019). <https://doi.org/10.1080/15252019.2018.1533501>
- Meta: Five years on, Reels reigns as India's top short-form video platform. Meta Newsroom. (2025). <https://about.fb.com/news/2025/09/five-years-on-reels-reigns-as-indias-top-short-form-video-platform/>
- Meyers-Levy, J., Loken, B.: Revisiting gender differences: what we know and what lies ahead. *J. Consumer Psychol.* **25**(1), 129–149 (2015). <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jcps.2014.06.003>
- Ohanian, R.: Construction and validation of a scale to measure celebrity endorsers' perceived expertise, trustworthiness, and attractiveness. *J. Advertising.* **19**(3), 39–52 (1990). <https://doi.org/10.1080/00913367.1990.10673191>
- Pan, M., Blut, M., Ghiassaleh, A., Lee, Z.W.Y.: Influencer marketing effectiveness: a meta-analytic review. *J. Acad. Mark. Sci.* **53**(1), 52–78 (2025)
- Petty, R.E., Cacioppo, J.T.: The elaboration likelihood model of persuasion. *Academic* (1986)
- Podsakoff, P.M., MacKenzie, S.B., Lee, J.-Y., Podsakoff, N.P.: Common method biases in behavioral research: a critical review of the literature and recommended remedies. *J. Appl. Psychol.* **88**(5), 879–903 (2003). <https://doi.org/10.1037/0021-9010.88.5.879>
- Rasmussen, L.: Parasocial interaction in the digital age: an examination of relationship building and the effectiveness of YouTube celebrities. *J. Social Media Soc.* **7**(1), 280–294 (2018)
- Rubin, A.M., Perse, E.M., Powell, R.A.: Loneliness, parasocial interaction, and local television news viewing. *Hum. Commun. Res.* **12**(2), 155–180 (1985). <https://doi.org/10.1111/j.1468-2958.1985.tb00071.x>
- Saturnus, Z., Mihale-Wilson, C., Hinz, O.: Influencer marketing on Instagram: optimal disclosure strategies and effects. *Electron. Markets* **34**(1), 60. (2024)
- Schouten, A.P., Janssen, L., Verspagen, M.: Celebrity versus influencer endorsements in advertising: the role of identification, credibility, and product-endorser fit. In: *Leveraged marketing communications*, pp. 208–231. Routledge (2021)
- Schreiner, M., Fischer, T., Riedl, R.: Impact of content characteristics and emotion on behavioral engagement in social media: literature review and research agenda. *Electron. Commer. Res.* **21**(2), 329–345 (2021)
- Sokolova, K., Kefi, H.: Instagram and YouTube bloggers promote it, why should I buy? How credibility and parasocial interaction influence purchase intentions. *J. Retail.Consum. Serv.* **53**, 101742. (2020). <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jretconser.2019.01.011>
- Sokolova, K., Perez, C.: You follow fitness influencers on YouTube. But do you actually exercise? How parasocial relationships, and watching fitness influencers, relate to intentions to exercise. *J. Retailing Consumer Serv.* **58**, 102276 (2021). <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jretconser.2020.102276>
- Spry, A., Pappu, R., Cornwell, T.B.: Celebrity endorsement, brand credibility and brand equity. *Eur. J. Mark.* **45**(6), 882–909 (2011). <https://doi.org/10.1108/0309056111119958>
- Tafesse, W., Wood, B.P.: Followers' engagement with Instagram influencers: the role of influencers' content and engagement strategies. *J. Retailing Consumer Serv.* **58**, Article102292 (2021)
- Till, B.D., Busler, M.: The match-up hypothesis: physical attractiveness, expertise, and the role of fit on brand attitude, purchase intent and brand beliefs. *J. Advertising.* **29**(3), 1–13 (2000). <https://doi.org/10.1080/00913367.2000.10673613>
- Tukachinsky, R.H.: Para-romantic love and para-friendships: development and assessment of a multiple-parasocial relationships scale. *Am. J. Media Psychol.* **3**(1/2), 73–94 (2010)
- Vorderer, P., Klimmt, C., Ritterfeld, U.: Enjoyment: at the heart of media entertainment. *Communication Theory.* **14**(4), 388–408 (2004). <https://doi.org/10.1111/j.1468-2885.2004.tb00321.x>

- Wang, S.W., Scheinbaum, A.C.: Enhancing brand credibility via celebrity endorsement: trustworthiness trumps attractiveness and expertise. *J. Advertising Res.* **58**(1), 16–32 (2018). <https://doi.org/10.2501/JAR-2017-042>
- Wixom, B.H., Todd, P.A.: A theoretical integration of user satisfaction and technology acceptance. *Inform. Syst. Res.* **16**(1), 85–102 (2005). <https://doi.org/10.1287/isre.1050.0042>
- Xiang, L., Zheng, X., Lee, M.K., Zhao, D.: Exploring consumers' impulse buying behavior on social commerce platform: the role of parasocial interaction. *Int. J. Inf. Manag.* **36**(3), 333–347 (2016). <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.ijinfomgt.2015.11.002>

Publisher's note Springer Nature remains neutral with regard to jurisdictional claims in published maps and institutional affiliations.

Springer Nature or its licensor (e.g. a society or other partner) holds exclusive rights to this article under a publishing agreement with the author(s) or other rightsholder(s); author self-archiving of the accepted manuscript version of this article is solely governed by the terms of such publishing agreement and applicable law.